

Harrington et al.: Aesthetic Measures for Automated Document Layout

Verified reference summary • Year: 2004 • Source bibliography: docs/REFERENCES.md

What the paper contributes

Harrington and colleagues propose automated document-layout measures including alignment, regularity, separation, balance, white-space fraction, white-space free-flow, proportion, uniformity, and page security.

Method / evaluation stance

A major lesson is that layout quality should not be combined only by a forgiving average. A single severe defect, such as overlap or unsafe margins, can dominate the reader’s impression even if other metrics are strong.

How slidekit uses it

slidekit already has hard lint gates for severe defects and advisory aesthetics for softer qualities. This paper supports future non-linear composition where one weak feature can meaningfully cap the overall score.

YAML vs HTML takeaway

The paper fits slidekit’s YAML strategy because most measures are computable over rectangles. HTML can also be measured, but source geometry avoids screenshot noise and lets the system explain which node caused the problem.

Bottom line

The paper supports a pragmatic split: use research-style rendered artifacts when the question depends on final pixels or human preference collection, but keep slidekit production decks in a constrained YAML IR so layout, linting, and agent fixes remain deterministic, inspectable, and cheap.

Primary slidekit mapping	balance / alignment / whitespace / overlap / contrast / richness / consistency, depending on the paper
Operational risk	HTML metrics can drift with rendering environment; YAML metrics can miss pixel-only effects. Use each where it is strongest.